CURIOUS SPAROOWS · ENCYCLOPEDIC INDEX · NEEDLE ARTS

EMBROIDERY

How women wrote stories in thread

Families, tools and threads · stitches · the Indian embroidery map · traditions of the world · 24 style cards with GI years · timeline · history · artisans and awards · ideas · practical guide

Parts	Sections	Sub-sections	Entries	Register rows
12	26	19	147	70

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How to Use This Booklet

This booklet is a map of embroidery: families, tools, stitches, the Indian and world maps, style cards, history, people, ideas and a practical guide.

Every entry has an ID (such as EMB-05.1). The same ID is the entry's address on curioussparoows.com.

How this booklet is organised

Parts 0 to 11: intro questions, map, families and tools, stitches, India, the world, registers, history and people, ideas, practical guide, reviews, navigation and sources.

Entries (☐): one or two lines each; tick when learned or made.

Registers: 24 style cards and the timeline.

How to explore it

Step 1. Read Part 0.

Step 2. Learn the ten core stitches (Part 3).

Step 3. Pick one Indian tradition near you (Part 4).

Step 4. Compare it with a world tradition (Part 5).

Step 5. Tick ☐ and keep a sampler log.

Our promise

Knowledge belongs to the artisans who created it. Motifs are described, never copied; makers and communities are credited. Where something could not be verified, we say so instead of guessing.

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PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: HOW DID WOMEN WRITE STORIES IN THREAD LONG BEFORE THEY WERE ALLOWED TO WRITE BOOKS?

About this Part. The doorway to the Embroidery section of the website, in the **Needle Arts** branch with Crochet (CRO), Knitting (KNT) and Sewing (SEW). One Gateway page, five Leaves and one Recap; each Leaf takes about two minutes.

EMB-00 The Gateway: How did women write stories in thread long before they were allowed to write books?

Web address: /embroidery/stories-in-thread/ · **Keywords:** embroidery for beginners, Indian embroidery styles, history of embroidery, embroidery stitches, hand embroidery vs machine

For most of history, most women were not taught to read or write. But they were taught to stitch. On quilts made from old saris in Bengal, on wedding shawls in Punjab, on dresses in Palestine and story cloths of the Hmong, women recorded births, weddings, gods, villages, jokes and griefs in thread. Embroidery is decoration, and it is also memory.

This short course asks one question in five steps: **what is embroidery, and what can it say?**

By the end you will be able to:

- Say what embroidery is and name its main families.
- Explain why the Bayeux "Tapestry" is really an embroidery.
- Describe the steps of making Lucknow's chikankari.
- Explain what a phulkari meant to a Punjabi family.
- Compare hand and machine embroidery fairly.

EMB-00.01 What is embroidery?

> **Short answer:** Embroidery is decorating a fabric (or leather, or paper) that already exists, using a needle and thread, and sometimes beads, mirrors, metal or cut cloth. It differs from weaving and knitting, which make the fabric itself, and from printing, which uses dye.

Keywords: what is embroidery, types of embroidery, embroidery vs weaving, surface embroidery, counted thread

The main families

- **Surface (free) embroidery**: stitches follow a drawn design (chikankari, crewel, kantha).
- **Counted-thread work**: stitches are counted over the fabric's threads (cross stitch, kasuti, blackwork).
- **Whitework**: white thread on white cloth (chikankari, Hardanger, broderie anglaise).
- **Goldwork and metal thread**: zardozi, gota.
- **Appliqué**: cloth shapes sewn onto cloth (Pipli, khatwa).
- **Beads, sequins and mirrors**: shisha work, aari with beads.
- **Quilting stitches**: running stitches through layers (kantha, sujani, sashiko).
- **Machine and digital embroidery**.

Why people embroider

To beautify, to show status or faith, to mark identity (your village, your community), to protect (mirrors against the evil eye), to mend and strengthen, to earn, and to remember.

> **Remember this:** Embroidery adds meaning to cloth, one stitch at a time.

Next: The world's most famous embroidery has the wrong name. Why?

EMB-00.02 Why is the Bayeux Tapestry not a tapestry?

> **Short answer:** A tapestry is woven: the picture is made on a loom as the cloth is made. The Bayeux Tapestry is wool thread stitched onto plain linen, so it is an embroidery. Nearly 70 metres long, it tells the story of the Norman conquest of England in 1066, and was probably made in England in the 1070s.

Keywords: Bayeux Tapestry embroidery, Bayeux stitch, Norman conquest 1066, medieval embroidery, laid and couched work

What it shows

About 58 scenes: Harold's oath, Halley's Comet (1066), the Channel crossing, the Battle of Hastings and Harold's death. A Latin caption runs above; animals and everyday scenes fill the borders.

How it was made

Wool yarn in about ten natural-dye colours, worked in **stem stitch** for outlines and **laid-and-couched work** (the "Bayeux stitch") for filling. It was probably commissioned by Bishop Odo, William's half-brother, and stitched by skilled English needleworkers, very likely women, whose names are lost.

News

The embroidery is kept at Bayeux in Normandy. A loan to the British Museum was announced in 2025 for 2026 to 2027 while its museum is rebuilt; check the museums' websites for current dates.

> **Remember this:** The Bayeux "Tapestry" is a 70-metre embroidered history book.

Next: From wool on linen to white on white: how is chikankari made?

EMB-00.03 How is chikankari made?

> **Short answer:** Chikankari, the white-on-white embroidery of Lucknow, passes through many hands: the cloth is cut, the design is **block-printed** in washable blue ink, embroiderers (mostly women working at home) work the stitches, and the piece is **washed** to remove the ink, then bleached, starched and ironed.

Keywords: chikankari process, Lucknow chikan, chikankari stitches, shadow work, chikan GI tag

The steps

1. **Cutting and stitching** the garment pieces.
2. **Chhapai**: printing the pattern with carved wooden blocks dipped in *neel* (indigo-based or washable ink).
3. **Embroidery**: over 30 named stitches, including *bakhiya* (shadow work, done from the back), *phanda* and *murri* (knots shaped like grains), *jaali* (a net made by pulling threads apart, no thread cut), *tepchi* (running stitch), *keel kangan* and *hool*.
4. **Dhulai**: washing in the Gomti-side washing ghats, bleaching, starching.
5. **Finishing**: ironing and checking.

Where it came from

Tradition credits Empress Nur Jahan (17th century) with popularising it; the Nawabs of Awadh patronised it in the 18th and 19th centuries. Lucknow Chikan Craft received a GI tag in 2008.

Who earns

Embroiderers are often paid by the piece through agents; groups such as SEWA Lucknow (1984) work for fairer wages.

> **Remember this:** Chikankari is teamwork: printer, embroiderer and washer make one garment.

Next: In Punjab, embroidery was a family diary. Why does every phulkari tell a story?

EMB-00.04 Why does every phulkari tell a family story?

> **Short answer:** A phulkari ("flower work") was a shawl embroidered by a Punjabi girl's grandmother, mother and aunts, and by the girl herself, for her wedding. Begun at her birth in many families, it held their hopes, songs and motifs from daily life. It was made for love, not for sale.

Keywords: phulkari history, bagh phulkari, Punjab embroidery, phulkari meaning, phulkari GI

How it is made

Untwisted silk floss (*pat*) is worked in **darning stitch from the back** of coarse hand-spun cotton (*khaddar*), dyed red or rust. The embroiderer counts threads; no pattern is drawn.

Kinds

- **Bagh** ("garden"): fully covered, so the cloth disappears.
- **Chope**: given by the maternal grandmother; worked on both sides.
- **Sainchi**: scenes of village life: trains, wrestlers, animals, jewellery.
- **Thirma**: on white cloth, worn by older women and widows.
- **Til patra** and others for gifts.

Loss and revival

Partition in 1947 scattered families and their phulkaris. Many are now in museums (the Philadelphia Museum of Art, the National Museum in Delhi). Phulkari has a GI tag (2011) for Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan, and today is made for sale, often on finer fabrics.

> **Remember this:** A phulkari is a family's blessing in silk.
>
> **Next:** Today machines embroider too. Can a machine embroider like a hand?

EMB-00.05 Can a machine embroider like a hand?

> **Short answer:** A machine can embroider faster, cheaper and more evenly than a hand, and computerised machines can copy almost any design. What it cannot give is the slight irregularity, the choice made at each stitch and the story of the maker. Both have their place; the honest thing is to label which is which.

Keywords: hand vs machine embroidery, Schiffli machine, computerised embroidery, how to identify hand embroidery, aari work

A short history of machines

- **1828**: Josué Heilmann's hand-embroidery machine (France).
- **1863**: Isaak Gröbli's **Schiffli** machine (Switzerland), using a shuttle like a sewing machine; made St Gallen a lace capital.
- **20th century**: multi-head machines.
- **1980s on**: computerised machines read digital design files.

How to tell

- **Back of the work**: machine work is very regular, often with a white bobbin thread and stabiliser paper; hand work shows knots and varied stitch lengths.
- **Repeats**: identical motifs suggest a machine.
- **Price and time**: a hand-embroidered sari can take weeks or months.

In between

India's *aari* (a hooked awl, like tambour) and *zardozi* workers use hand tools at great speed; "computer embroidery" units now work beside them in Surat, Lucknow and Delhi.

> **Remember this:** Machines copy the look; hands carry the story. Ask, and label honestly.
>
> **Next:** The Recap.

EMB-00.06 Recap: thread as language

- **EMB-00.01**: Embroidery decorates existing cloth; it has eight main families.
- **EMB-00.02**: The Bayeux "Tapestry" is an embroidery of the 1070s.
- **EMB-00.03**: Chikankari is printed, stitched and washed by different hands.
- **EMB-00.04**: A phulkari was a family's wedding blessing.
- **EMB-00.05**: Machines embroider well, but differently.

Where to go next: the Master Map (Part 1) and the Indian embroidery map (Part 4). **Quick quiz:** What is the difference between a tapestry and an embroidery? What is *jaali*? What does *bagh* mean?

PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF EMBROIDERY

EMB-01 The hierarchy: from Forest to Leaf

Before you start — EMB-01. The Forest is "Embroidery". Its Trees are families of embroidery, tools and materials, stitches, the Indian embroidery map, the world map, and the human side (history, people, ideas, practice). **See also:** CRO-01, KNT-01, SEW-01.

- ☐ **EMB-01.1 Families**: surface, counted thread, whitework, metal thread, appliqué, beads and mirrors, quilting stitches, machine and digital (EMB-00.01; Part 2).
- ☐ **EMB-01.2 Tools and materials** (Part 2).
- ☐ **EMB-01.3 Stitches** (Part 3).
- ☐ **EMB-01.4 The Indian embroidery map** (Part 4).
- ☐ **EMB-01.5 The world map** (Part 5).
- ☐ **EMB-01.6 Registers**: style cards and the timeline (Part 6).
- ☐ **EMB-01.7 The human side**: history, people and awards (Part 7), ideas (Part 8), practical guide (Part 9), reviews (Part 10).

PART 2 — FAMILIES, TOOLS AND MATERIALS

EMB-02 Families of embroidery

☐ **EMB-02.1 Surface embroidery**: free stitches over a drawn design; crewel (wool), silk shading, kantha, chikankari.

☐ **EMB-02.2 Counted-thread embroidery**: cross stitch, kasuti, blackwork, Hardanger, needlepoint (canvas work), pattern darning (phulkari).

☐ **EMB-02.3 Whitework**: chikankari, cutwork, drawn-thread and pulled-thread work, broderie anglaise, Ayrshire and Dresden work.

☐ **EMB-02.4 Goldwork and metal thread**: zardozi, gota patti, mukaish (*badla*, tiny flattened wire dots), *tilla*, European church goldwork.

☐ **EMB-02.5 Appliqué and patchwork**: Pipli, khatwa, Rabari patchwork; reverse appliqué (the *mola* of Panama's Guna people).

☐ **EMB-02.6 Beadwork, sequins and mirror work**: shisha (*abhla*) mirrors, aari beadwork, Zulu and Native American beadwork.

☐ **EMB-02.7 Quilting stitches**: kantha, sujani, sashiko, ralli.

☐ **EMB-02.8 Machine and digital embroidery**: free-motion, Schiffli, multi-head computerised (EMB-00.05).

EMB-03 Tools and materials

☐ **EMB-03.1 Needles**: crewel or embroidery (sharp, long eye), tapestry (blunt, for counted work), chenille, beading, milliner's (for bullion knots); the *aari* hook.

☐ **EMB-03.2 Hoops and frames**: round hoops, slate and scroll frames; the Indian *adda* or *karchob*, a large wooden frame at which several zardozi workers sit together.

☐ **EMB-03.3 Threads**: stranded cotton (six strands; Anchor and DMC are the common brands), pearl cotton, silk floss (*pat*), crewel wool, metallic *zari* (once real silver and gold; now mostly metallised polyester), rayon machine thread.

☐ **EMB-03.4 Fabrics**: even-weave linen and aida (for counting), muslin (*mulmul*), cambric, khaddar, silk, velvet, organza, matty cloth (used in Indian schools for cross stitch).

☐ **EMB-03.5 Transferring designs**: tracing with carbon or light, pricking and pouncing with powder, block printing (chikankari), water-soluble pens and stabilisers, iron-on transfers.

☐ **EMB-03.6 Extras**: thimble, embroidery scissors, mirrors, beads, sequins (*sitara*), *gota* ribbon, stabiliser.

PART 3 — STITCHES

EMB-04 The stitch families

Before you start — EMB-04. Mary Thomas's *Dictionary of Embroidery Stitches* (1934) sorted hundreds of stitches into families. Almost every tradition on Earth uses the same few moves under different names; Indian names are given where they are common.

☐ EMB-04.1 Flat and line stitches

☐ **EMB-04.1a Running stitch**: in and out in a line; the base of kantha, sujani and sashiko; *tepchi* in chikankari; *kachcha tanka* in tailoring.

☐ **EMB-04.1b Back stitch**: each stitch goes back to meet the last; a solid line; *bakhiya* in Hindi (in chikankari, *bakhiya* means shadow work done with a double back stitch).

☐ **EMB-04.1c Stem stitch**: overlapping slanted stitches; a rope-like line for stems; *dandi tanka*.

☐ **EMB-04.1d Split stitch**: each stitch pierces the last; fine outlines in medieval English work (*opus anglicanum*).

☐ **EMB-04.1e Satin stitch**: straight stitches side by side to fill a shape; *bharwan* or *bharai*; Kashmiri and Chinese silk work.

☐ **EMB-04.1f Long-and-short stitch**: staggered satin stitches for shading ("needle painting").

☐ **EMB-04.1g Darning stitch**: rows of running stitch counted over threads; phulkari, Kasuti's *negi*.

☐ **EMB-04.1h Couching**: a thick or metal thread laid on the surface and tied down with small stitches; zardozi, Bayeux work.

☐ EMB-04.2 Looped, chained and knotted stitches

☐ **EMB-04.2a Chain stitch**: a line of loops; *zanjeer*; the main stitch of aari, Kashmiri crewel and Kutch Mochi work.

☐ **EMB-04.2b Lazy daisy (detached chain)**: single loops as petals.

☐ **EMB-04.2c Blanket and buttonhole stitch**: edge stitches; hold mirrors and appliqué; *kaj tanka*.

☐ **EMB-04.2d Feather stitch**: open loops to left and right; a branching line.

☐ **EMB-04.2e Fly stitch**: a V or Y shape.

☐ **EMB-04.2f French knot**: thread wrapped round the needle to make a dot; *phanda* is chikankari's cousin.

☐ **EMB-04.2g Bullion knot**: a long coil; roses; *murri* is related.

☐ **EMB-04.2h Shisha stitch**: a frame of stitches that holds a mirror without glue.

☐ EMB-04.3 Crossed and counted stitches

☐ **EMB-04.3a Cross stitch**: X-shaped stitches counted on even-weave cloth; *dosuti*; used worldwide.

☐ **EMB-04.3b Herringbone stitch**: crossed diagonal stitches; done from the back it gives shadow work; Kutch interlacing is built on it.

☐ **EMB-04.3c Holbein (double running) stitch**: looks the same on both sides; Kasuti's *gavanti* and European blackwork.

☐ **EMB-04.3d Tent stitch**: the small slanted stitch of needlepoint.

☐ **EMB-04.3e Interlacing stitch**: the *Sindhi taropa* or Kutchi *bavaliyo*, a woven lattice.

☐ **EMB-04.3f Pulled and drawn work**: tightening or removing threads to make holes; chikankari *jaali*, Hardanger.

PART 4 — THE INDIAN EMBROIDERY MAP

About this Part. India in depth, region by region. GI years are from the GI Registry and may be checked at ipindia.gov.in. Each style gets its place, stitches, materials, motifs and makers. Style cards are in EMB-09.

EMB-05 North India

☐ **EMB-05.1 Chikankari (Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh)**: white-on-white shadow work, knots and jaali on muslin and now georgette (EMB-00.03); GI 2008.

☐ **EMB-05.2 Zardozi (Lucknow, Bareilly, Delhi, Agra, Hyderabad, Bhopal)**: metal-thread embroidery with *zari*, *dabka* (coiled wire), *salma*, *sitara* and stones on velvet and silk, worked on the *adda*; Persian *zar* (gold) and *dozi* (work); patronised by the Mughals; Lucknow Zardozi GI 2013.

☐ **EMB-05.3 Mukaish or badla (Lucknow)**: tiny dots and patterns of flattened metal wire pressed through the cloth; often added to chikan.

☐ **EMB-05.4 Phulkari and bagh (Punjab, Haryana)**: EMB-00.04; GI 2011.

☐ **EMB-05.5 Kashida, sozni and aari (Kashmir)**: *sozni* is fine needlework on pashmina shawls, often identical on both sides (*dorukha*); *aari* or crewel is hooked chain stitch on wool and cotton for furnishings; *tilla* is gold-thread work on pherans; motifs of chinar leaf, paisley (*buta*), iris and birds; Kashmir Sozani Craft GI 2008.

☐ **EMB-05.6 Chamba rumal (Himachal Pradesh)**: square cloths embroidered in double satin stitch (*dorukha*), showing scenes from the Krishna legends and the Ramayana in the style of Pahari miniature painting; GI 2007.

☐ **EMB-05.7 Gota patti (Rajasthan: Jaipur, Ajmer, Khandela)**: gold and silver ribbon (*gota*) cut into petals and leaves and stitched down; Rajasthani bridal wear.

☐ **EMB-05.8 Danka and karchobi (Udaipur and Rajasthan)**: small metal squares couched with zari; raised zardozi.

☐ **EMB-05.9 Rampur and Agra work**: fine appliqué (Rampur's *khatwa*-style patti ka kaam of Aligarh, known as *phool patti*) and zardozi of Agra.

EMB-06 West India

☐ **EMB-06.1 Kutch embroidery (Gujarat)**: many community styles with mirrors and bright silk or cotton; Kutch Embroidery GI 2013.

☐ **EMB-06.2 Rabari**: bold mirrors, chain stitch outlines and back-stitch (*bakhiya*) details by the pastoral Rabari community; black wool and cotton.

☐ **EMB-06.3 Ahir**: flowing floral and bird motifs in chain stitch with many small mirrors.

☐ **EMB-06.4 Banni, Mutwa, Jat and Sodha (Suf, Khaarek, Pakko)**: the Maldhari and Sodha communities of northern Kutch; *suf* is counted triangles worked from the back; *khaarek* is geometric bars; *pakko* is dense and raised; Mutwa work uses the tiniest mirrors.

☐ **EMB-06.5 Mochi bharat (aari)**: silk chain stitch with a cobbler's hooked awl, once made for Kutch royalty.

☐ **EMB-06.6 Kathiawar and Saurashtra**: Kathi and Kanbi embroideries, *torans*, *chaklas* (wall squares) and bead work.

☐ **EMB-06.7 Parsi gara (Mumbai, Gujarat)**: Chinese-origin silk embroidery of birds and flowers on saris, brought through the China trade of the 19th century.

☐ **EMB-06.8 Banjara or Lambani (Maharashtra, Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra)**: mirrors, cowrie shells, coins and bright patchwork with strong geometric stitches; Sandur Lambani embroidery (Karnataka) GI 2010.

EMB-07 South, East and North-East India

☐ **EMB-07.1 Kasuti (Karnataka: Dharwad, Hubballi)**: counted-thread work on Ilkal saris with four stitches: *gavanti* (double running), *murgi* (zigzag), *negi* (darning) and *menthi* (cross stitch); motifs of temple towers, chariots, lamps and elephants; GI 2006.

☐ **EMB-07.2 Toda embroidery (Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu)**: *pukhoor*, red and black wool darning on white cotton shawls (*poothkuli*) by Toda women; looks woven; GI 2013.

☐ **EMB-07.3 Kantha (West Bengal and Bangladesh)**: layers of old saris and dhotis quilted with running stitch, with borders and figures; *nakshi kantha* carries stories; Nakshi Kantha GI 2008.

☐ **EMB-07.4 Sujani (Bihar)**: quilts of old cloth with running-stitch backgrounds and chain-stitch outlines; today's sujani shows social themes; Sujini Embroidery Work of Bihar GI 2006.

☐ **EMB-07.5 Khatwa (Bihar)**: appliqué for tents and canopies; Applique (Khatwa) Work of Bihar GI.

☐ **EMB-07.6 Pipli appliqué (Odisha)**: bright cut-cloth canopies, umbrellas and lampshades, made for the Jagannath temple's Rath Yatra; *chandua*; GI 2008.

☐ **EMB-07.7 Manipuri embroidery**: dark-red silk on the border of the *phanek* (women's wrap); *Shaphee Lanphee* shawls (GI 2014) woven and embroidered by Meitei women with motifs once awarded to Naga warriors.

☐ **EMB-07.8 Naga and North-East**: embroidery, cowries and beadwork on woven shawls marking tribe and status; Mizo and Arunachali textiles are mostly woven.

☐ **EMB-07.9 Aari work (pan-India)**: chain stitch with a hooked needle on a frame; Tamil Nadu and Andhra's bridal blouse "aari work", Kashmir, Kutch, Lucknow.

☐ **EMB-07.10 Shisha (mirror) work**: Gujarat, Rajasthan, Haryana, Sindh; once mica or blown-glass pieces, now cut mirror.

☐ **EMB-07.11 Convent and church embroidery (Goa, Kerala, Tamil Nadu)**: whitework, cross stitch and lace taught in mission schools.

PART 5 — THE WORLD EMBROIDERY MAP

EMB-08 Embroidery traditions of the world

☐ **EMB-08.1 China**: four famous schools: Su (Suzhou, fine silk, double-sided work), Xiang (Hunan), Shu (Sichuan) and Yue (Guangdong); silk embroidery goes back over 2,000 years.

☐ **EMB-08.2 Japan**: *sashiko* ("little stabs", white running stitch on indigo, for strengthening work clothes) and *nihon shishu* (*nui*), silk and gold embroidery for kimono.

☐ **EMB-08.3 Korea**: *jasu*, silk embroidery on screens, robes and wrapping cloths.

☐ **EMB-08.4 Central Asia**: Uzbek and Tajik *suzani*, large dowry hangings with suns, flowers and pomegranates in chain and couching (*basma*) stitch.

☐ **EMB-08.5 Persia and Turkey**: Rasht patchwork embroidery, Ottoman court embroidery, Turkish towels and *oya*.

☐ **EMB-08.6 Palestine**: *tatreez*, cross-stitch on dresses (*thobe*) whose patterns show a woman's village; inscribed by UNESCO in 2021.

☐ **EMB-08.7 Ukraine and Eastern Europe**: the *vyshyvanka* embroidered shirt; Russian, Romanian and Bulgarian shirts; Hungary's Matyó flowers (UNESCO, 2012).

☐ **EMB-08.8 Western Europe**: English crewel (Jacobean wool work), *opus anglicanum* (medieval English church embroidery, famed across Europe), the Bayeux embroidery, blackwork, samplers; Swedish and Norwegian folk embroidery, Hardanger; Portuguese Madeira and Castelo Branco work; Italian Assisi work.

☐ **EMB-08.9 The Americas**: Mexico's Otomí *Tenango* animals and flowers; Guatemalan *huipil* blouses; Panama's Guna *molas*; North American quilting and samplers.

☐ **EMB-08.10 South-East Asia**: Hmong *paj ntaub* ("flower cloth"): cross stitch, reverse appliqué and, after the wars of the 1970s, story cloths; Vietnamese and Philippine embroidery (piña cloth).

☐ **EMB-08.11 Africa**: Hausa embroidered robes (Nigeria), Kuba cloth appliqué (Congo), Ethiopian and Moroccan (Fez) embroidery.

☐ **EMB-08.12 South Asia beyond India**: Sindhi and Balochi embroidery and *ralli* quilts (Pakistan), Bangladeshi nakshi kantha, Afghan *khamak*.

PART 6 — REGISTERS

EMB-09 Embroidery style cards (register of 24)

Before you start — EMB-09. The brief's card has eight fields; it is split into two linked tables. GI years as registered in India; "—" means not applicable.

☐ EMB-09.1 Card A: place, stitches, materials

Style	Region	Main stitches	Materials	Motifs
Chikankari	Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh	Shadow work, phanda, murri, jaali, tepchi	White cotton thread on muslin, georgette	Flowers, creepers, paisley
Zardozi	Lucknow, Bareilly, Hyderabad	Couching	Zari, dabka, sequins on velvet, silk	Florals, peacocks, jaal
Phulkari	Punjab, Haryana	Darning from the back	Silk floss on khaddar	Geometric flowers, village life
Sozni	Kashmir	Fine satin and stem stitches	Silk or wool on pashmina	Paisley, chinar, floral jaal
Kashmiri aari (crewel)	Kashmir	Hooked chain stitch	Wool on cotton or wool	Flowers, vines, birds
Chamba rumal	Himachal Pradesh	Double satin stitch	Untwisted silk on muslin	Krishna legends, Raas
Gota patti	Rajasthan	Appliqué of ribbon, hemming	Gota ribbon on silk, georgette	Leaves, flowers, birds
Rabari	Kutch, Gujarat	Chain, back stitch, mirrors	Cotton, wool, mirrors	Scorpions, parrots, temples
Suf	Kutch (Sodha)	Counted satin from the back	Silk or cotton on cotton	Triangles, peacocks
Mochi aari	Kutch, Gujarat	Hooked chain stitch	Silk on satin	Flowers, parrots, dancers
Parsi gara	Mumbai, Gujarat	Satin, long-and-short, knots	Silk on silk	Cranes, roosters, peonies
Lambani	Karnataka, Telangana, Maharashtra	Many geometric stitches, patchwork	Cotton, mirrors, cowries, coins	Geometric bands
Kasuti	Karnataka	Gavanti, murgi, negi, menthi	Cotton or silk on handloom	Gopuram, chariot, lamp, elephant
Toda	Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu	Darning (pukhoor)	Red and black wool on white cotton	Geometric bands, buffalo horns
Kantha	West Bengal	Running stitch	Old saris, coloured border threads	Lotus, tree of life, stories
Sujani	Bihar	Running and chain stitch	Old cloth, cotton thread	Sun, fertility, social themes
Pipli appliqué	Odisha	Appliqué, hemming, chain	Coloured cotton cloth, mirrors	Sun, Rahu, peacocks, elephants
Manipuri (Shaphee Lanphee)	Manipur	Satin stitch on woven cloth	Cotton	Sun, moon, elephant, horse
Suzhou embroidery	China	Fine satin, split, random stitches	Silk on silk	Cats, goldfish, landscapes
Sashiko	Japan	Running stitch	White cotton on indigo	Waves, hemp leaf, tortoiseshell
Suzani	Uzbekistan, Tajikistan	Chain, basma couching	Silk or cotton on cotton	Suns, pomegranates, vines
Tatreez	Palestine	Cross stitch	Silk or cotton on linen or cotton	Cypress, stars, village patterns
Crewel (Jacobean)	England	Stem, long-and-short, knots	Wool on linen twill	Tree of life, exotic leaves
Hmong paj ntaub	Laos, Vietnam, Thailand, diaspora	Cross stitch, reverse appliqué	Cotton	Snail, elephant foot, story scenes

☐ EMB-09.2 Card B: makers, GI status and where to see it

Style	Community or artisans	GI status (India)	Museum examples
Chikankari	Mostly Muslim women home-workers; printers and washermen	Lucknow Chikan Craft, 2008	State Museum, Lucknow; V&A
Zardozi	Mostly men at the adda (karigars)	Lucknow Zardozi, 2013	National Museum, Delhi; V&A

Phulkari	Punjabi women, for family use	Phulkari, 2011	Philadelphia Museum of Art; National Museum, Delhi
Sozni	Kashmiri men (sozankars)	Kashmir Sozani Craft, 2008	SPS Museum, Srinagar; V&A
Kashmiri aari	Kashmiri craftsmen	Covered by Kashmiri craft listings (check)	Calico Museum, Ahmedabad
Chamba rumal	Women of Chamba, once royal households	Chamba Rumal, 2007	Bhuri Singh Museum, Chamba; V&A
Gota patti	Artisans of Jaipur, Ajmer, Khandela	Not verified	City Palace Museum, Jaipur
Rabari	Rabari women	Kutch Embroidery, 2013	LLDC Museum, Ajrakhpur; Shrujan
Suf	Sodha Rajput and Meghwal women	Kutch Embroidery, 2013	LLDC Museum; Kala Raksha
Mochi aari	Mochi community	Kutch Embroidery, 2013	Calico Museum; V&A
Parsi gara	Parsi families; Chinese craftsmen originally	—	CSMVS, Mumbai
Lambani	Banjara (Lambani) women	Sandur Lambani Embroidery, 2010	Sandur Kushala Kala Kendra
Kasuti	Women of north Karnataka	Kasuti Embroidery, 2006	Karnataka state museums
Toda	Toda women	Toda Embroidery, 2013	Tribal Research Centre, Ooty
Kantha	Bengali women	Nakshi Kantha, 2008	Gurusaday Museum, Kolkata; Philadelphia Museum of Art
Sujani	Women of Bhusura, Muzaffarpur	Sujini Embroidery Work of Bihar, 2006	Bihar Museum, Patna
Pipli appliqué	Darji community of Pipli	Pipli Applique Work, 2008	Odisha State Museum
Manipuri	Meitei women	Shaphee Lanphee, 2014	Manipur State Museum
Suzhou embroidery	Su embroidery studios	—	Suzhou Embroidery Museum
Sashiko	Farming and fishing families of northern Japan	—	Amuse Museum collections; V&A
Suzani	Brides and their families	—	State Museum of Applied Art, Tashkent
Tatreez	Palestinian women	—	Palestinian Museum, Birzeit; British Museum
Crewel	English needleworkers; Royal School of Needlework	—	V&A; Hardwick Hall
Hmong paj ntaub	Hmong women	—	Smithsonian collections

EMB-10 The embroidery timeline (year-wise register)

Year	Event	Where	Why it matters
c. 30,000 years ago	Beaded clothing in the Sunghir burials	Russia	Earliest decorated garments
c. 2500 BCE	Bronze needles and decorated cloth figures at Indus sites	South Asia	Early needlework in India
5th to 3rd centuries BCE	Chain-stitch silk embroideries in Chinese tombs	China	Oldest surviving embroideries
c. 1070s	Bayeux embroidery	England, Normandy	Embroidered history
1250 to 1350	Height of *opus anglicanum*	England	Medieval church embroidery
16th to 17th centuries	Mughal karkhanas (workshops) for zardozi and floor spreads	Agra, Lahore, Delhi	Court patronage
17th century	Gujarat chain-stitch quilts and Bengal *colchas* exported to Europe	India	Indian embroidery in world trade
1828	Heilmann's embroidery machine	France	Mechanisation begins
1863	Schiffli machine	Switzerland	Industrial embroidery
1872	Royal School of Needlework founded	London	Training and conservation
1934	Mary Thomas's stitch dictionary	UK	Standard stitch names
1949	Calico Museum of Textiles	Ahmedabad	India's great textile collection

1952	All India Handicrafts Board (Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay)	India	Craft revival
1965	National Awards for master craftspersons begin	India	Recognition of artisans
1972	SEWA founded by Ela Bhatt	Ahmedabad	Women artisans organise
1981	Dastkar founded	Delhi	Craft and livelihood NGO
1980s	Computerised embroidery machines	Japan, Germany	Digital embroidery
2002	Shilp Guru awards begin	India	Highest honour for master craftspersons
2006 to 2014	GI tags for Kasuti, Sujani, Chamba rumal, Chikan, Kantha, Pipli, Phulkari, Kutch, Toda and others	India	Protection of regional styles
2021	Palestinian tatreez inscribed by UNESCO	UNESCO	Embroidery as heritage

PART 7 — HISTORY, PEOPLE AND AWARDS

EMB-11 The history of embroidery

☐ **EMB-11.1 Before history**: bone needles and beads; decorated skins.

☐ **EMB-11.2 The ancient world**: Chinese silk chain stitch; Egyptian appliqué and beadwork (Tutankhamun's tunic); references to embroidered cloth in Vedic and epic literature and in Megasthenes's account of flowered muslins.

☐ **EMB-11.3 Medieval courts and churches**: Byzantine gold, *opus anglicanum*, the Bayeux embroidery; Sultanate and Mughal India's royal workshops (*karkhanas*), described in the *Ain-i-Akbari*.

☐ **EMB-11.4 Trade and empire**: Indian chintz and embroideries for Europe; the Kashmir shawl craze; colonial exhibitions; mission-school needlework.

☐ **EMB-11.5 Machines**: Heilmann, Schiffli, the sewing machine's zigzag, multi-head and computerised machines.

☐ **EMB-11.6 Decline and revival**: cheap machine goods and Partition hurt many crafts; Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, Pupul Jayakar, the Crafts Council of India (1964), SEWA, Dastkar, Shrujan (1969, Kutch), Kala Raksha, Kalaraksha Vidhyalaya and Rangsutra revived them.

☐ **EMB-11.7 Today**: designer collaborations, online sales by artisans, GI protection, copying by machines, and embroidery as contemporary art.

EMB-12 Artisans, designers, museums and awards

☐ **EMB-12.1 Honours in India**: the **National Awards** for master craftspersons (since 1965), the **Shilp Guru** awards (since 2002) and the Sant Kabir awards (for weavers), all from the Ministry of Textiles, and Padma awards. Latest lists are published at handicrafts.nic.in and through PIB; they were not individually verified for this edition.

☐ **EMB-12.2 Master artisans (examples)**: Lalita Vakil (Chamba rumal; Padma Shri 2022); Pabiben Rabari (Rabari embroidery entrepreneur); Chandaben Shroff (1933 to 2016, founder of Shrujan; Rolex Award 2006); Rumana and Ayub Khan and other chikan Shilp Gurus of Lucknow; Kasuti and Toda artisans' cooperatives.

☐ **EMB-12.3 Revivalists and scholars**: Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, Pupul Jayakar, Jasleen Dhamija (*Asian Embroidery*, 2004), Laila Tyabji (Dastkar), Judy Frater (Kala Raksha, Somaiya Kala Vidya), Ruth Clifford, Rta Kapur Chishti.

☐ **EMB-12.4 Designers who work with embroidery**: Ritu Kumar, Abu Jani and Sandeep Khosla (chikankari), Sabyasachi Mukherjee, Rahul Mishra, Anita Dongre (gota patti), Manish Malhotra; Mumbai's embroidery ateliers that supply Paris couture houses (Chanakya, founded 1984; the Chanakya School of Craft, 2016).

☐ **EMB-12.5 World figures**: Mary Thomas, Erica Wilson (crewel), Jessie Newbery and Ann Macbeth (Glasgow School), May Morris (daughter of William Morris), Constance Howard; contemporary artists Tracey Emin, Ghada Amer, Faith Ringgold (story quilts), the Gee's Bend quilters.

☐ **EMB-12.6 Museums**: Calico Museum of Textiles (Ahmedabad), National Crafts Museum (New Delhi), LLDC Living and Learning Design Centre (Kutch), V&A (London), Royal School of Needlework, Textile Museum (Washington), Musée de la Tapisserie de Bayeux, China National Silk Museum (Hangzhou).

PART 8 — IDEAS: PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY

EMB-13 Embroidery as language, identity and care

☐ **EMB-13.1 Women's language and memory**: kantha, phulkari, samplers and story cloths as records made by women who were denied writing; Rozsika Parker, *The Subversive Stitch* (1984).

☐ **EMB-13.2 Identity**: motifs that tell village, tribe, marriage status and faith (tatreez, Rabari, Naga).

☐ **EMB-13.3 Protest and politics**: suffragette banners (1908 to 1914); Chile's *arpilleras* under Pinochet; the AIDS Memorial Quilt (1987); Hmong story cloths; Gandhi's khadi movement as a textile politics.

☐ **EMB-13.4 Therapy and well-being**: needlework was used to help shell-shocked soldiers after the First World War; today's studies of textile crafts link them with calm and connection (CRO-00.05, KNT-13).

☐ **EMB-13.5 Fair trade and livelihoods**: piece rates, middlemen, credit to artisans, design copying; the Craftmark (All India Artisans and Craftworkers Welfare Association) and Handloom Mark; buying direct.

☐ **EMB-13.6 Authenticity and ownership**: who may use a community's motifs? GI tags, cultural appropriation and respectful collaboration.

PART 9 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE

EMB-14 First stitches, care and buying

☐ **EMB-14.1 A first sampler**: on cotton cloth in a 15 cm hoop, rows of running, back, stem, chain, lazy daisy, satin, blanket, French knot, cross and herringbone stitch; then a small motif using five of them.

☐ **EMB-14.2 Starting and ending threads**: waste knots and weaving in, not bulky knots; use about 45 cm of thread; separate strands.

☐ **EMB-14.3 Patterns**: draw your own, trace from nature, or use copyright-free historical designs; credit living designers.

☐ **EMB-14.4 Washing and care**: hand-wash gently in cool water with mild soap; never wring; dry in shade; iron face down on a towel so stitches stay raised; dry-clean zardozi and store it wrapped in muslin, away from damp (real metal thread tarnishes).

☐ **EMB-14.5 Buying authentic craft**: look at the back; ask who made it and where; look for GI, Craftmark or cooperative labels; buy from state emporia, craft bazaars (Dilli Haat, Dastkar) and artisan cooperatives; expect a fair price.

☐ **EMB-14.6 Learning more**: Royal School of Needlework stitch bank (free online), state craft institutes, NIFT and NID craft clusters, local teachers.

PART 10 — REVIEWS AND VOICES

EMB-15 Critics' Corner, the experts said I say, and My Review Desk

☐ **EMB-15.1 Books**: Mary Thomas (1934); Jasleen Dhamija, *Asian Embroidery* (2004); Sheila Paine, *Embroidered Textiles* (1990); Rozsika Parker (1984); John Gillow and Nicholas Barnard, *Indian Textiles* (2008); Clare Hunter, *Threads of Life* (2019); Rta Kapur Chishti's sari books.

☐ **EMB-15.2 Review template**: the piece, book or kit in two lines (dated price); what experts said (3 to 5 named views, in my words); what I say (stitch quality, back of the work, materials, design, honesty of labelling); who made it and were they paid fairly; my rating on a clear five-point scale; tags and try-next links.

PART 11 — NAVIGATION, SOURCES AND NOTES

EMB-16 Tag dictionary and site map

☐ **EMB-16.1 Tags**: #embroidery; family tags (#surface #countedthread #whitework #goldwork #applique #mirrorwork #quilting #machine); stitch tags (#running #chain #satin #crossstitch #frenchknot #couching); Indian style tags (#chikankari #zardozi #phulkari #kantha #sozni #kutch #rabari #kasuti #chambarumal #toda #pipli #sujani #lambani #gotapatti #aari); world tags (#sashiko #suzani #tatreez #crewel #bayeux #hmong); theme tags (#gi #women #history #fairtrade #protest).

☐ **EMB-16.2 Cross-links**: Crochet (CRO), Knitting (KNT), Sewing (SEW: quilting, garments); Technology (textile technology: TEC-07); Movies and Books (costume, craft stories); the Curriculum Index (Art and Craft, History, Home Science) and the Exam Guide (RPSC/RSSB questions on Rajasthan's handicrafts such as gota patti, and on GI tags).

☐ **EMB-16.3 Web addresses**: /embroidery/ (home, Gateway), /embroidery/stories-in-thread/<leaf>/ , /embroidery/families/<family>/ , /embroidery/tools/<tool>/ , /embroidery/stitches/<stitch>/ , /embroidery/india/<state>/<style>/ , /embroidery/world/<country>/<style>/ , /embroidery/history/<era>/ , /embroidery/people/<name>/ , /embroidery/awards/<award>/<year>/ , /embroidery/ideas/<topic>/ , /embroidery/guide/<topic>/ , /embroidery/reviews/<item>/ .

☐ **EMB-16.4 Search phrases to own**: "types of Indian embroidery by state", "chikankari stitches names", "phulkari history", "kantha stitch", "embroidery GI tags India", "basic embroidery stitches for beginners", "hand vs machine embroidery difference", with Hindi lines ("bharat ki kadhai ke prakar", "kadhai ke tanke", "chikankari kaise hoti hai").

EMB-S Sources and credits

☐ **India**: Ministry of Textiles, Development Commissioner (Handicrafts); GI Registry, Chennai; Crafts Council of India; Calico Museum of Textiles; National Crafts Museum; Shrujan and LLDC; SEWA; Dastkar.

☐ **World**: Victoria and Albert Museum; Royal School of Needlework (RSN Stitch Bank); Musée de la Tapisserie de Bayeux; UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage lists; Philadelphia Museum of Art (phulkari and kantha collections).

☐ **Books**: Jasleen Dhamija; Mary Thomas; Sheila Paine; Rozsika Parker; Gillow and Barnard; Judy Frater, *Threads of Identity* (1995).

EMB-E Editor's notes

1. **The Bayeux Tapestry** is called an embroidery throughout, with its popular name kept for search.
2. **"Kashida"** is used as the general Kashmiri word for embroidery, with sozni, aari and tilla as its kinds.
3. **Nur Jahan and chikankari** is marked as tradition.
4. **GI years** are given where confirmed; gota patti and Kashmiri crewel are marked "not verified" or "check".
5. **Award winners**: the systems are described and a few well-documented names given; latest yearly lists are pointed to official sites rather than guessed.
6. **Added beyond the brief**: mukaish, Parsi gara, khatwa, Shaphee Lanphee, the Chanakya atelier, protest embroidery, Craftmark, and how to tell hand from machine work.

EMB-T My Embroidery Tracker

Tick ☐ as you learn each stitch and study each style. Keep a stitch diary: date, stitch or style, sample made, where I saw a real piece, who made it.

Progress tracker

Part	Sections	Explored ☐	Started	Finished
PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: HOW DID WOMEN WRITE	7			

STORIES IN THREAD LONG BEFORE THEY WERE ALLOWED TO WRITE BOOKS?				
PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF EMBROIDERY	1			
PART 2 — FAMILIES, TOOLS AND MATERIALS	2			
PART 3 — STITCHES	1			
PART 4 — THE INDIAN EMBROIDERY MAP	3			
PART 5 — THE WORLD EMBROIDERY MAP	1			
PART 6 — REGISTERS	2			
PART 7 — HISTORY, PEOPLE AND AWARDS	2			
PART 8 — IDEAS: PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY	1			
PART 9 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE	1			
PART 10 — REVIEWS AND VOICES	1			
PART 11 — NAVIGATION, SOURCES AND NOTES	4			